Operation Pied Piper: What Was It Like to Be an Evacuee?

Key Enquiry Question: Why did 1.5 million British children leave their families behind, and what can a brown luggage label teach us?

LESSON 02
WORKSHEET 1



Source A: *A London police sergeant checks the cardboard luggage label pinned to a young evacuee's coat, accompanied by an escorting nun at a railway station in September 1939. (Imperial War Museum LN 6194)*

HISTORICAL READING • OPERATION PIED PIPER

On Friday 1 September 1939—two days before war was declared—the British government launched **Operation Pied Piper**. Fearing that German bomber planes would immediately drop poison gas and bombs on industrial cities, authorities ordered the mass evacuation of vulnerable civilians.

In just three days, nearly **1.5 million schoolchildren and mothers** were relocated from target cities like London, Manchester, and Liverpool to rural counties. Children gathered at their school gates carrying a single suitcase, their boxed gas mask, and a government identity label tied to their coat button.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • The Evacuee Luggage Label

PRIMARY SOURCE SKILLS



Source B: *London schoolchildren wearing official cardboard luggage labels pinned to their lapels during Operation Pied Piper (Imperial War Museum HU 36871).*

1. What essential information did teachers write on each child's luggage label before boarding the train?

2. Why was having a physical tag securely pinned or tied to each child's coat so crucial in the chaos of busy stations?

Task 2: Active Chronology • The Journey to the Countryside

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • 8:00 AM

The School Gate Farewell

Children line up outside school with teachers. Parents must say goodbye at the gate—they are not allowed on the train.

Why were parents barred from the stations?

STAGE 2 • 11:30 AM

The Secret Destination

Trains packed with singing children head into the countryside. Neither children nor teachers know where they are going.

How did children feel on the journey?

STAGE 3 • 4:00 PM

The Billeting Hall Selection

Arrival at the village hall. Billeting officers call out: "I'll take that one!" Local villagers choose their evacuee guests.

Why was selection often hurtful?

Task 3: Historical Inquiry • What Did a British Evacuee Pack & Why?

HISTORICAL EMPATHY & REASONING

Explain why each of these 5 items was considered essential by parents and government billeting officers for a child travelling alone to the countryside (Refer to your full-page suitcase drawing on Sheet 3):

1. Warm Winter Overcoat & Sturdy Walking Shoes — WEATHER & DURABILITY

Why was durable, warm country clothing essential for city children arriving in rural villages?

2. Cardboard Gas Mask Box & Pinned Coat Luggage Label — SAFETY & IDENTITY

Why did teachers strictly inspect that luggage labels were securely tied to coat buttons before boarding?

3. Government Food Ration Book & National Identity Card — DAILY SUSTENANCE

Why was it impossible for a foster family to feed an evacuee without handing over their official ration coupons?

4. Personal Wash Kit: Toothbrush, Comb, Soap & Face Flannel — HYGIENE & HEALTH

Why did the Ministry of Health urge parents to pack a complete washing kit for every child?

5. Comfort Keepsake: Family Photograph, Teddy Bear, or Favourite Book — EMOTIONAL RESILIENCE

How did packing one cherished comfort item help a 10-year-old cope with homesickness on their first night?

Task 4: Thinking Heads • Two Different Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 The 10-Year-Old London Evacuee

What thoughts and worries might a 10-year-old London evacuee have on their first night?

2 The Country Host Mother

What thoughts and responsibilities might a country host mother feel welcoming evacuees?

Task 5: Master Synthesis • Postcard Back to London

EXTENDED WRITING

WARTIME POSTCARD TO MUM AND DAD

POSTAGE 1½D

Dearest Mum and Dad,

With lots of love, _____

TO:

Mr & Mrs _____

Street: _____

District: London, E3 _____

H EVACUEE'S PACKING SUITCASE • OPERATION PIED PIPER (1939)

na: You are being evacuated from London to rural Devon. Draw, color, and pack your essential evacuee belongings inside your vintage suitcase below.

LESSON 02
SUITCASE CRAFT

L.C.C. EVACUEE TAG
NAME: _____ • DEVON

OPEN SUITCASE CANVAS • DRAW, COLOR & PACK YOUR ESSENTIAL ITEMS HERE

Draw and arrange your warm clothes, gas mask box, ration book, wash kit, and comfort keepsake freely inside your vintage suitcase.